

Parent Guide — middle / module-10-herbs-aushadhi

IKS Curriculum

Table of Contents

Parent Guide — Module 10: Auṣadhi (Herbs)

Your child's age: Middle (Grades 6–8) · **Module length:** 10 sessions × 45 min over ~2 weeks

What your child is learning

The Ayurvedic concept of *auṣadhi* — herbs and medicinal plants — applied to six common kitchen and garden herbs:

Sanskrit	Common name	Botanical name
<i>tulasī</i>	Holy basil / tulsi	<i>Ocimum tenuiflorum</i>
<i>nimba</i>	Neem	<i>Azadirachta indica</i>
<i>haridrā</i>	Turmeric / haldi	<i>Curcuma longa</i>
<i>adraka</i>	Ginger / adrak	<i>Zingiber officinale</i>
<i>yavānī</i>	Ajwain / carom	<i>Trachyspermum ammi</i>
<i>pudīnā</i>	Mint / pudina	<i>Mentha species</i>

For each herb, students learn: - How to identify it by leaf shape and smell - The main active compound modern chemistry has identified (curcumin, gingerol, eugenol, etc.) - The traditional use within the Ayurvedic doṣa framework (heating vs. cooling) - The safety question: how much is too much

How we teach it

The framing is **observational botany + modern chemistry + cultural knowledge**, in that order. We start with what your child can see and smell, then connect to the chemistry textbook, then situate the Sanskrit framework as one historical Indian way of organising the knowledge.

We do **not** teach this instead of modern medicine. We teach it as a complementary intellectual framework — and as a way to think more carefully about plants in your child's everyday food.

NEP 2020 §4.6 (Integration of Indian Knowledge Systems) supports this approach.

The most important takeaway

Food amounts are safe. Therapeutic doses are a question for trained practitioners — not for students.

Your child will hear this every class. It is the single most important point of the module. If your child comes home and starts giving family members herbal advice, gently redirect:

- “What’s a culinary amount?” (a pinch, a slice, a leaf) — safe.
- “What’s a therapeutic dose?” (capsules, oils, multi-gram daily) — needs a doctor.

Specific safety topics

We explicitly cover:

1. **Neem hepatotoxicity** — neem in concentrated form (especially neem oil) can damage the liver. We do not let students chew neem leaves in class.
2. **Essential oils are not for ingestion** at this age level.
3. **Pregnancy and children** — herb dosing differs significantly. This is a clinical question, not a homework question.
4. **“Natural” is not the same as “safe.”** Poison ivy is natural. Dose matters more than origin.

If you use Ayurvedic preparations at home, this module will probably make your child more curious — and slightly more questioning. That’s intentional.

Homework you’ll see

- Smell-and-identify tasks (find this herb in your kitchen; bring a leaf if you have one).
- Drawing each herb’s leaf shape.
- A short kitchen-garden seed-sowing activity (tulsi or mint — both grow easily on a sunny balcony).
- A project — a 6-card herb identification deck.
- 4 writing prompts (mix of reflection, explanatory, argumentative).

How to help

Helpful: - Walk your child through your spice rack. Identify each herb together. - If you have a balcony or yard, plant a tulsi or mint cutting with your child. - Tell stories — “your grandmother used to make X with ginger when...” — but flag them as family stories, not as universal medical advice. - Read the safety message in this guide with your child.

Not helpful: - Encouraging your child to *prescribe* herbs to relatives. They are not trained for this and this module does not teach prescription. - Mocking either Ayurveda or modern medicine. We teach them as complementary, not in opposition. - Pushing capsule-form herbs on your child. The whole-plant culinary use is what’s safe; the concentrated extracts are a different question.

Citation standard

By Middle band, projects must engage with at least one source. For this module, the historical source is the *Auṣadhi-sūkta* (Ṛgveda 10.97) — a real Vedic hymn addressing plants as healing beings — cited at the level of “from this hymn” rather than as a verbatim quote your child needs to memorise. The modern compound names (curcumin, gingerol, eugenol, thymol, menthol, azadirachtin) are chemistry-textbook basics.

This trains the habit: real sources from real texts and real chemistry, not invented references.

What success looks like

By end of module, your child can: - Identify all six herbs by sight and smell. - Name the main active compound in each. - Distinguish food-amount safe use from therapeutic use. - Read a wellness claim (“turmeric cures arthritis!”) and ask: what’s the evidence, what’s the dose, what’s the source? - Explain why ginger is “heating” and mint is “cooling” in the Ayurvedic framework, and what that means at a basic chemical level.

On respect across traditions

Some families treat the tulsi plant as sacred. Others use Ayurvedic remedies routinely; others not at all. The classroom frame is *both/and*: tulsi is a plant with specific chemistry AND a plant with cultural significance in many Indian households. We hold both without privileging either.

Want to go deeper?

The Senior band (Grades 9–12) version of this module includes: - The *Auṣadhi-sūkta* in IAST with translation. - Chemical structures of curcumin, gingerol, eugenol. - Comparative ethnobotany (how does Traditional Chinese Medicine treat ginger? How does European herbal tradition treat mint?) - Critical evaluation of common claims using actual evidence categories.

Preview: [curriculum/senior/module-10-herbs-aushadhi/README.md](#).

10-Day Lesson Plan

Module 10 (Middle) — 10-Day Lesson Plan

At a glance

Day	Session title	Lesson file	Activity / assessment
1	What is an <i>Auṣadhi</i> ?	days/day-01-what-is-aushadhi.md	Six-herb walkaround
2	<i>Tulasī</i> — The Household Herb	days/day-02-tulasi.md	Smell-and-sketch; exit ticket
3	<i>Nimba</i> — The Bitter	days/day-03-	quizzes/formative.md Part A

Day	Session title	Lesson file	Activity / assessment
	Teacher	nimba.md	
4	<i>Haridrā</i> — Golden Root, Modern Molecule	days/day-04-haridra.md	Golden-milk preparation demo
5	<i>Adraka</i> — Fresh vs Dried	days/day-05-adraka.md	Ginger-tea demo; quizzes/formative.md Part B
6	<i>Yavānī</i> — Seeds for the Stomach	days/day-06-yavani.md	Ajwain-water demo
7	<i>Pudīnā</i> — The Cooling Green	days/day-07-pudina.md	Mint variety taste-id
8	Doṣa Lens — Heating and Cooling	days/day-08-dosha-lens.md	activities/activity-02-sort-by-virya.md
9	Project Session — Build the Herb Deck	days/day-09-project-session.md	activities/activity-03-deck-build.md
10	Showcase + Summative	days/day-10-showcase-summative.md	quizzes/summative.md + project

Pacing notes

- Days 2–7 are one herb per day. If you only have 6 sessions total, drop Days 7 and 9 (combine mint into the Day 8 doṣa lens; rush the project into Day 10 itself).
- Day 4 and Day 5 both have a short food-preparation demo. **Check school policy on cooking-in-class before the module starts.** If not allowed, both demos can be replaced with a smell-only station — and the “golden milk” / “ginger tea” become take-home recipes.
- Activity 02 (sort by *vīrya*) needs the doṣa vocabulary from Module 4. If your students haven’t taken Module 4, allocate 10 min on Day 8 to introduce *uṣṇa* / *śīta* / *vāta* / *pitta* / *kapha* before the sort.

Suggested running theme

Open each class with the same prompt on the board: **“Which herb did you smell or eat at home since our last class?”** Two students share for 30 seconds each. By Day 10 most students will have actively noticed the herbs already living in their kitchens.

Pacing for the safety reminder

The **“these are not prescriptions”** line gets repeated **at the start of every herb-day lesson** (Days 2–7). Yes, every one. It is the most important takeaway of the module. Students should be able to recite it back by Day 5.

Formative vs. summative weight

- Formative quizzes (Day 3 Part A; Day 5 Part B) — **not graded**. Use them to decide who needs the pre-class refresher on Day 6.
- Summative quiz (Day 10) is closed-book, 20 min, 25 marks. Combined with the project rubric (15 marks), the module total is 40 marks.

What students leave the module with

- The ability to identify six common herbs by sight + smell.
- One project artefact (the 6-card herb deck) that they can take home or leave for the classroom library.
- The habit of asking “*what’s in this?*” and “*is it safe in this amount?*” before believing a wellness claim.
- The understanding that traditional knowledge and modern phytochemistry are **complementary**, not competing.

Homework

Homework — Herbs — Auṣadhi (Middle)

Light daily tasks. Each takes 10–15 minutes.

1. **Day 1 — What is Auṣadhi?** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
2. **Day 2 — Tulsī — Holy Basil** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
3. **Day 3 — Neem — Bitter Healer** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
4. **Day 4 — Turmeric — Golden Root** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
5. **Day 5 — Ginger — Warming Root** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
6. **Day 6 — Ajwain — Carom Seed** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
7. **Day 7 — Mint — Cooling Leaf** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
8. **Day 8 — Herbs and the Doṣas** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
9. **Day 9 — Build the Class Deck** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)
10. **Day 10 — Final Share and Assessment** · Write 2 sentences about today’s concept. (~10 min)

Notes

- Homework is intended to consolidate what was learned in class, not introduce new content.
- If a child struggles, the parent should consult the teacher rather than push.
- Capstone project days (Module 15) may have lighter daily homework so students can focus on the project.